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Thorn: Biggest OL vs. DL Mismatches, Week 1

BRANDON THORN // SEP 11, 2026



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The goal of a real-life NFL defense is to prevent the other team from scoring points. When we select a defense to roster, we're trying to score the most fantasy points. It's a subtle shift in thinking, but an important one.

The optimal way to select a defense in DFS is to think in terms of big events, not points allowed. Just 2.5% of games last season ended in a shutout, and only 9.7% ended with one team being held to six points or fewer. In other words, targeting the "points allowed" category is a fool's errand.

The real fantasy points come from sacks, forced fumbles, interceptions, and defensive touchdowns. These events are by far most likely to happen when a quarterback is under pressure. The best possible outcome on a single play for our defense is a strip sack that results in a defensive touchdown, as we get one DraftKings point for the sack, two for the fumble recovery, and six for the touchdown.

With that in mind, below you'll find the biggest mismatches between defensive and offensive lines for Week 1. The objective is to project QB pressure through film study, injuries, scheme, coaching, and talent.

Week 1 Bye Week: N/A

Week 1 Matchups

2026 NFL season • OL and DL rankings



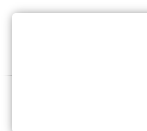
ROAD TEAM	HOME TEAM	GAME TIME
Chicago Bears OL RANK: 7 • DL RANK: 31 OL > DL	Carolina Panthers OL RANK: 25 • DL RANK: 26	Sunday 01:00 PM ET
Tampa Bay Buccaneers OL RANK: 3 • DL RANK: 6	Cincinnati Bengals OL RANK: 12 • DL RANK: 17	Sunday 01:00 PM ET
New Orleans Saints OL RANK: 6 • DL RANK: 28	Detroit Lions OL RANK: 14 • DL RANK: 19	Sunday 01:00 PM ET
Buffalo Bills OL RANK: 4 • DL RANK: 21	Houston Texans OL RANK: 27 • DL RANK: 2	Sunday 01:00 PM ET
Baltimore Ravens OL RANK: 21 • DL RANK: 16	Indianapolis Colts OL RANK: 5 • DL RANK: 9	Sunday 01:00 PM ET
Cleveland Browns OL RANK: 31 • DL RANK: 15 DL > OL	Jacksonville Jaguars OL RANK: 30 • DL RANK: 11 DL > OL	Sunday 01:00 PM ET
Atlanta Falcons OL RANK: 20 • DL RANK: 25	Pittsburgh Steelers OL RANK: 16 • DL RANK: 4 DL > OL	Sunday 01:00 PM ET
New York Jets OL RANK: 13 • DL RANK: 20 DL > OL	Tennessee Titans OL RANK: 32 • DL RANK: 8	Sunday 01:00 PM ET
Arizona Cardinals OL RANK: 24 • DL RANK: 29	Los Angeles Chargers OL RANK: 15 • DL RANK: 22	Sunday 04:25 PM ET
Miami Dolphins OL RANK: 28 • DL RANK: 32	Las Vegas Raiders OL RANK: 26 • DL RANK: 27	Sunday 04:25 PM ET
Green Bay Packers OL RANK: 29 • DL RANK: 30	Minnesota Vikings OL RANK: 17 • DL RANK: 24	Sunday 04:25 PM ET
Washington Commanders OL RANK: 23 • DL RANK: 23	Philadelphia Eagles OL RANK: 2 • DL RANK: 3 OL > DL DL > OL	Sunday 04:25 PM ET
Dallas Cowboys OL RANK: 18 • DL RANK: 12	New York Giants OL RANK: 11 • DL RANK: 14	Sunday 08:20 PM ET
Denver Broncos OL RANK: 1 • DL RANK: 7 DL > OL	Kansas City Chiefs OL RANK: 19 • DL RANK: 13	Monday 08:15 PM ET

DL Rankings – Week 1

1. Rams



2. Texans
3. Eagles
4. Steelers
5. Seahawks
6. Bucs
7. Broncos
8. Titans
9. Colts
10. 49ers
11. Jaguars
12. Cowboys
13. Chiefs
14. Giants
15. Browns
16. Ravens
17. Bengals
18. Patriots
19. Lions
20. Jets
21. Bills
22. Chargers



23. Commanders

24. Vikings

25. Falcons

26. Panthers

27. Raiders

28. Saints

29. Cardinals

30. Packers

31. Bears

32. Dolphins

OL Rankings – Week 1

1. Broncos

2. Eagles

3. Bucs

4. Bills

5. Colts

6. Saints

7. Bears

8. Seahawks



9. 49ers

10. Rams

11. Giants

12. Bengals

13. Jets

14. Lions

15. Chargers

16. Steelers

17. Vikings

18. Cowboys – LG **Tyler Smith** is out for the next 4-6 weeks due to thumb surgery.

19. Chiefs – LT **Josh Simmons** is out this week with a back injury.

20. Falcons

21. Ravens

22. Patriots

23. Commanders

24. Cardinals

25. Panthers

26. Raiders

27. Texans

28. Dolphins



29. Packers

30. Jaguars

31. Browns

32. Titans

Biggest Week 1 DL > OL Mismatches

1. Eagles DL (3rd) > Commanders OL (23rd)

2. Jaguars DL (11th) > Browns OL (31st)

3. Steelers DL (4th) > Falcons OL (20th)

4. Browns DL (15th) > Jaguars OL (30th)

5. Broncos DL (7th) > Chiefs OL (19th)

6. Jets DL (20th) > Titans OL (32nd)

Biggest Week 1 OL > DL Mismatches

1. Eagles OL (2nd) > Commanders DL (23rd)

2. Bears OL (7th) > Panthers DL (26th)

DL > OL

1. Eagles DL > Commanders OL



Key matchups: Edge rushers Jonathan Greenard, Jalyx Hunt, and Nolan Smith vs. OTs Brandon Coleman and Josh Conerly; DT Jalen Carter vs C Nick Allegretti

Notes: DE Jonathan Greenard is listed as day-to-day. While he's expected to play, he'll likely be on a pitch count. LT Laremy Tunsil is expected to be out for the majority of the season.

Washington's pass-protection unit took a major hit with the loss of star left tackle **Laremy Tunsil** to a torn triceps, costing the unit its best player. This will force the sneakily underrated **Brandon Coleman** into the lineup, but even if he is solid, that is a steep drop-off from Tunsil's elite level of play. With **Sam Cosmi** the unit's only clear-cut high-end starter, the remaining three starters face more pressure to perform, and the Eagles have the front to ensure a slow start in Week 1.

Jalen Carter had an epic battle with Cosmi when they faced off in 2024, so that individual matchup will be must-see. Whenever Carter is isolated against center **Nick Allegretti**, however, the integrity of the pocket will be compromised. Add in a deep rotation off the edge led by **Jonathan Greenard** and **Jalyx Hunt**, and the young tackles will also have their hands full on the road in Philadelphia.

2. Jaguars DL > Browns OL

Key matchups: Edge rushers Josh Hines-Allen and Travon Walker vs OTs Spencer Fano and Tytus Howard

Notes: Browns RG Teven Jenkins went from limited in Wednesday's practice with a back injury to out on Thursday. Rookie third-round pick **Austin Barber** will start in his place if he doesn't play.

The Jaguars quietly have one of the best edge-rushing duos in the NFL, led by **Josh Hines-Allen** and the ascending **Travon Walker** on the other side. They get the luxury of facing what should be one of the league's bottom-

tier lines at home to open the year. Rookie **Spencer Fano** is making his first start against Hines-Allen, who has a potent blend of speed and power to test the rookie's mediocre anchor. Walker, on the other side, is more of a pure power rusher whose long-arm technique can give any tackle fits, including Howard.

Inside, the Browns will likely start rookie **Austin Barber** at right guard. Veteran interior rusher **Arik Armstead** is past his prime, but he has enough juice to provide a Welcome to the NFL moment for Barber should he get isolated against him, especially if the Browns are playing from behind and forced into obvious passing downs, which is expected.

3. Steelers DL > Falcons OL

Key matchups: DT Cam Heyward vs. C Ryan Neuzil; edge rushers Alex Highsmith, T.J. Watt, and Nick Herbig vs. OTs Jake Matthews and Jawaan Taylor

Notes: Falcons QB Tua Tagovailoa suffered an oblique injury at practice on Thursday, and Cooper Rush took over first-team reps.

The Steelers are yet again expected to have a dynamic defensive front, only now inside a revamped scheme led by shrewd play-caller **Patrick Graham**. The edge trio of **Alex Highsmith**, **T.J. Watt**, and **Nick Herbig** is on the podium for best in the NFL, while **Cam Heyward**, **Keanu Benton**, and **Derrick Harmon** are at a similar level on the interior.

This six-deep group will be a tall task to handle for the Falcons' mediocre pass-protecting line, especially if **Tua Tagovailoa**'s ultra-quick trigger is out of the lineup. LT **Jake Matthews** has taken a significant step back over the last two seasons despite maintaining incredible durability, while **Jawaan Taylor** is adequate. Both, however, cannot consistently hold up one-on-one in extended drop-back passing situations, while the interior is similarly physically or technically outmatched.

4. Browns DL > Jaguars OL

Key matchups: DE Jared Verse vs. LT Anton Harrison; DT Maliek Collins vs. RG Ezra Cleveland

Notes: The Jaguars switched Anton Harrison from right tackle to left tackle this offseason, Cole Van Lanen from left tackle to right tackle, and Ezra Cleveland from left guard to right guard.

Jacksonville left tackle **Anton Harrison** is moving back to his college position after starting his first three seasons on the right side, while **Ezra Cleveland** is switching from left to right guard. Harrison's move also bumped **Cole Van Lanen** to right tackle, while rookie **Emmanuel Pregnon** is starting at left guard. Jacksonville's buttoned-up, run-oriented system and rhythmic passing game are well equipped to insulate the line, but it will face a stiff test against **Jared Verse** and **Maliek Collins**. Harrison was a solid but inconsistent right tackle, and now playing a new — albeit somewhat familiar — position on the left against the league's best bull rush in Verse is a recipe for early struggles. Cleveland, meanwhile, is well below average, at a new spot, and facing one of the more underrated rushers in the league in Collins.

Cleveland's offense will need to be respectable to keep this game close and, therefore, provide the pass rush opportunities to rush the passer. But the defensive infrastructure is in place for a stingy performance, with two outsized advantages in Verse and Collins against their respective opponents.

5. Broncos DL > Chiefs OL

Key matchups: Edge rusher Nik Bonitto vs. LT Khalil Benson; DT Zach Allen vs. LG Kingsley Suamataia



Notes: Second-year LT Josh Simmons is out this week with a back injury, forcing rookie undrafted free agent Khalil Benson into the starting lineup.

The Chiefs suffered a significant blow to their line with **Josh Simmons** expected to miss this game and undrafted rookie **Khalil Benson** making his first start against one of the most high-octane speed rushers in the league, **Nik Bonitto**. Bonitto's get-off and ability to access the corner are elite, while Benson is a lumbering, power-oriented blocker who has virtually no chance to block him one-on-one in true drop-back situations without help. This, in turn, will provide increased isolated matchups for **Zach Allen** against LG **Kingsley Suamataia** and **Jonah Ellis/Dondrea Tillman** against RT **Jaylon Moore**.

OL > DL

1. Eagles OL (2nd) > Commanders DL (23rd)

The Eagles' offensive line enters the season healthy after an injury-riddled 2025 campaign while also entering a new era in terms of the system it will be operating in. Longtime OL coach **Jeff Stoutland** retired, and now the team is set to make a radical transition into a Shanahan-esque scheme with more expected help in pass protection than these tackles have ever seen. That should help mitigate the loss of Stoutland's expertise in the short term while raising the floor on an already high bar. Washington has a couple of above-average rushers in **Odafe Oweh** and **Daron Payne**, but they will first need to stop the run to earn the right to rush the passer. Even if they do, Oweh will likely be overmatched against both tackles, especially **Lane Johnson**.

[Lane Johnson, Philadelphia Eagles, Brandon Thorn DL/OL Mismatches,](#)

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